

For true versatility, robots need to be mobile. Robot companions must be able walk on two legs. And this is still an engineering challenge. Bipedal movement is essentially a continuous, controlled fall that's avoided only by precisely timing each step.

Humans do it without thinking, so it seems simple. But the fact is, it takes a fabulous amount of computational horsepower just to prevent a two-footed, walking bot from falling. Early mobile robots had to drag a cable connecting them to a fairly big computer—which meant limited mobility.

A lot of the focus in robotics now is on creating bots that walk like humans without help. And a lot of this behaviour—including walking—is learned by the robot, instead of being hard-coded. It may seem that hardcoding the behaviour is simpler, but it's not: it's easier to program robots so they learn by themselves.

According to some sources, computing power increases a thousandfold every 15 years. If this is the case and if the trend continues it's only a matter of time before even little metal pets like the Aibo become intelligent. Still, many experts believe truly smart robots are inevitable, given the ever-growing power of computer chips. One hopes so.

Household Help

Despite all the advances and inventions in robotics, one unanimous feeling is that the future of robots is at home. That is, home robots; your maid or butler. These creatures would be expected to wake you up and have your morning cuppa ready, draw your bath, iron your clothes, make your breakfast, clean the house, probably read you your newspaper, make your lunch... the list continues.

But our existing technology may prove restrictive, and while work continues in this field, there is a certain amount of scepticism that has to be countered before intelligent robots can really become a part of mainstream life.

There are, for example, reasons to believe that research in the US is not as extensive as in Japan thanks to Hollywood's depiction of robots as evil beings. In Japan, though, robots have been widely shown as helpers and may hence just be accepted more easily. But what about the rest of the world? Being fed off Hollywood may even mar the widespread use of robots elsewhere.

Some interesting research from the creators of the Roomba has shown that more than anything else, people want to know if the robot can 'clean their floors'. The second most wanted feature humans want in a robot is the ability to wash clothes. Roomba seems to have fulfilled the first desire. Time to wait and watch how long before the next is fulfilled.

Can I Afford One?

US, Europe and Japan notwithstanding, can the rest of the world afford a robot even if they became reality? Developers and manufacturers predict that the prices of these household helpers may not exceed those of a high-end laptop. Say around \$1,000 (Rs 45,000). In which case, your dream bot may just be reality. Start saving! ☒

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